



The war of AIs in the domain of security.

Jagdish Mahapatra – Chief of Channels & Alliances, Managed Services, Cloud and Specialist Sales – APAC – McAfee

We talk security with one of the topmost experts in the domain.

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

d We are seeing couple of technology mediums becoming very omnipresent such as IoT, along with that, almost every company talks about the security aspect being baked in from the get go. However, when you look at the trends, it seems that the IoT devices are the most vulnerable because every company has different security standards. There is no unified standard, one company's lax security policies appear stringent from another company's perspective. Do you believe, this trend of infection is going to improve or get worse?

Jagdish: IoT means everything that is physical today will have an IP address. Firstly, I'm excited. We all are, because

imagine the efficiency that it'll bring to the economy. IoT is great and it'll change our lives forever. However, they are all 100-year old products, and the manufacturers never thought about security since that aspect was not part of the business model. To understand the challenge here, let's look at how IoT works. You have the IoT on the device, which then talks to the edge receiver and then there is the cloud where the data is sent. There is a fair amount of communication happening from the IoT device to the cloud, and you can't have everything being sent over. Some amount of computing has to happen on the device. That makes it complex. How do we culturally change these sensor builders and device builders to think 'security first'? That's going to be a major challenge in the first

10 years of IoT adoption. Eventually, we'll get there because when you have AI coming in, it starts to take control of many things. Until then, we will probably see an increase in cybersecurity attacks. Have you ever used the search engine called Shodan?

d Oh yes, I once found my home router popping up on Shodan due to a firm-ware glitch.

Jagdish: Yeah, it's creepy. I had my neighbour's webcam popping up with a default password. If I wanted, I could have snuck into their house and created havoc. That's the world that we're living in and that's what worries me more.

d AI can be used for both good and bad. Security companies are going to use AI to improve their heuristic detection algorithms so that they can stop malware. However, it's also going to be used by attackers. Thus, if we are to take one concept, let's say DDoS, would AI improve the situation or worsen it?

Jagdish: My answer to this question would be the summary of my upcoming TED talk. This is exactly what I am going to be talking about. This is exactly the problem. Technologies such as Blockchain or AI are fundamentally going to make us more secure. Blockchain is phenomenal, in terms of how it is going to safeguard our contracts and our transactions. You can't have better security than that. Also, AI will help folks like us offer better security services. There's no doubt about that. However, these will be the same tools used by our adversaries to harm us. My belief is that what will finally win this war is the human behaviour. The fact that my neighbour did not even care to change the default password of his webcam is the problem. It's not the technology. When AI does come in, it's going to be used equally by the good guys and the bad guys. Look at the biggest hack of last year, Equifax. 150 million records. There was no dearth of technology. What they lacked were measures to counter basic human habits – which failed them. I think that if we can fix this, then 90 percent of the problems will go away. We're letting the bad guys get ahead of us. That's what I'm worried about. And then we have the singularity coming in, whenever it is coming in. It's worrying. **d**